

Causes, Symptoms, Types & Treatment

 my.clevelandclinic.org/health/diseases/9290-depression

November 16, 2016

What is depression?

Depression is a [mood disorder](#) that causes a persistent feeling of sadness and loss of interest in things and activities you once enjoyed. It can also cause difficulty with thinking, memory, eating and [sleeping](#).

It's normal to feel sad about or grieve over difficult life situations, such as losing your job or a divorce. But depression is different in that it persists practically every day for at least two weeks and involves other symptoms than sadness alone.

There are several types of depressive disorders. Clinical depression, or major depressive disorder, is often just called "depression." It's the most severe type of depression.

Without treatment, depression can get worse and last longer. In severe cases, it can lead to [self-harm](#) or death by [suicide](#). The good news is that treatments can be very effective in improving symptoms.

What are the types of depression?

The American Psychiatric Association's [Diagnostic Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders, Fifth Edition \(DSM-5\)](#) classifies depressive disorders as the following:

- [Clinical depression \(major depressive disorder\)](#): A diagnosis of major depressive disorder means you've felt sad, low or worthless most days for at least two weeks while also having other symptoms such as sleep problems, loss of interest in activities or change in appetite. This is the most severe form of depression and one of the most common forms.
- [Persistent depressive disorder \(PDD\)](#): Persistent depressive disorder is mild or moderate depression that lasts for at least two years. The symptoms are less severe than major depressive disorder. Healthcare providers used to call PDD dysthymia.
- [Disruptive mood dysregulation disorder \(DMDD\)](#): DMDD causes chronic, intense irritability and frequent anger outbursts in children. Symptoms usually begin by the age of 10.
- [Premenstrual dysphoric disorder \(PMDD\)](#): With PMDD, you have [premenstrual syndrome](#) (PMS) symptoms along with mood symptoms, such as extreme irritability, anxiety or depression. These symptoms

improve within a few days after your [period](#) starts, but they can be severe enough to interfere with your life.

- **Depressive disorder due to another medical condition:** Many medical conditions can create changes in your body that cause depression. Examples include [hypothyroidism](#), [heart disease](#), [Parkinson's disease](#) and cancer. If you're able to treat the underlying condition, the depression usually improves as well.

There are also specific forms of major depressive disorder, including:

People with [bipolar disorder](#) also experience episodes of depression in addition to [manic](#) or [hypomanic](#) episodes.

Who does depression affect?

Depression can affect anyone — including children and adults.

Having certain risk factors makes it more likely that you may develop depression. For example, the following conditions are associated with higher rates of depression:

How common is depression?

Depression is common. Researchers estimate that nearly 7% of adults in the United States have depression every year. More than 16% of U.S. adults — around 1 in 6 people — will experience depression at some point in their lifetime.

However, researchers believe that these estimates are lower than reality, as many people don't seek medical help for symptoms of depression and don't receive a diagnosis.

Approximately 4.4% of children in the United States have depression.